

Inner Power

Bruce meets friends in a nice restaurant. They order lunch. The waiter is rude to Bruce. The waiter is rude to Bruce again. Bruce just smiles. Bruce won't let a rude waiter spoil his day.

Bruce is a martial artist. A martial artist learns to fight to protect himself. To some, he is the greatest martial artist of all time. Bruce could say something rude to the waiter. Bruce could hurt the rude waiter. But Bruce won't. Being a martial artist means more than kicks and punches.

Fact: Bruce believes you learn how to fight so you don't have to fight.

Bruce's approach to life is simple. He controls his thoughts. He controls his actions. What can Bruce gain by hurting the waiter with words or blows? Bruce has no need to show off his skills. Bruce is happy to walk away.

Early Years

Bruce was born in 1940. Bruce was born in San Francisco. His parents are from Hong Kong. His father, Lee Hoi-chuen, is an actor. His mother, Grace Ho, is from a rich family. Bruce has two brothers and two sisters.

Fact: Bruce is born in the Year of the Dragon.

When Bruce is still a baby, the family moves back to Hong Kong. His family lives in Kowloon. As a young boy, Bruce works as an actor. He stars in more than 20 movies. Bruce also likes to dance. Bruce wins contests as a dancer.

Fact: Bruce stars in his first film at the age of three months.

At school, the boys bully Bruce. The boys think Bruce is weak because he acts. Bruce wants to defend himself. Bruce studies a martial art called Wing Chun when he is 16 years old. Bruce joins a gang and gets into street fights. The police know about Bruce.

Fact: Yip Man teaches Wing Chun to Bruce.

A New Life

Bruce's parents want him to stay out of trouble. They want Bruce to stay out of prison. Bruce's parents send him back to San Francisco. There, Bruce lives with his older sister. Bruce works in a restaurant.

Bruce goes to university in 1961. He teaches martial arts to pay his bills. Bruce studies philosophy. Bruce loves to study philosophy. He reads book after book about philosophy. Bruce finds a love he follows all his life.

In university, Bruce finds an even deeper love. Bruce meets Linda. She is a student in his martial arts class. Soon, Linda and Bruce go out on dates. In 1964, they become husband and wife.

Fact: Bruce and Linda have two children.

The Teacher

Bruce leaves university. Bruce wants to teach martial arts full time. He believes most students take classes to become street fighters. But most students are taught to swing wide with kicks and punches. Those types of moves won't win a street fight.

Fact: Bruce opens three martial arts studios.

Bruce wants to change how martial arts is taught. Dance is taught step by step. Martial arts are often taught the same way. Bruce thinks martial arts should be taught like a street fight. Short, quick moves win a street fight.

Being able to kick in the right way is important. Being able to punch in the right way is important. But a person needs more than those skills. Bruce believes people must train their bodies and their minds.

Many other martial artists dislike Bruce. They say, "You are too young to teach a martial art. You should not teach martial arts to non-Chinese." But Bruce does not care what others say or think. Bruce is his own person.

The Thinker

People must train their minds to be open. People must train their minds to be calm.

Bruce believes in balance. Bruce likes to balance 'thinking time' and 'doing time'.

Bruce also believes that people should be like water.

Bruce says: "Empty your mind, be formless. Shapeless like water. Now you put water into a cup, it becomes the cup. You put water into a bottle, it becomes the bottle. You put it in a teapot, it becomes the teapot."

The Actor

It is 1967. Bruce still teaches and he starts to act again. Bruce is an actor in the TV program The Green Hornet. Bruce fights crime in this TV show. People in Hong Kong watch this show. Bruce becomes famous in Hong Kong.

Fact: The Green Hornet lasts for only one season.

Bruce wants to act on the big screen. But Hollywood isn't ready for an Asian leading man. Bruce returns to Hong Kong in 1971. In Hong Kong, Bruce makes a movie. Bruce calls the movie Fists of Fury.

Fact: Fists of Fury is a box-office hit.

By 1972, Hollywood sees that Bruce is a star. Hollywood asks Bruce to act in a movie. Bruce opens the door for other Asian actors. Asian directors get jobs. Asian stuntmen get jobs. Bruce helps other Asians reach their goals.

Fact: Bruce Lee is known as the King of Kung Fu.

Bruce acts in many movies. He does his own stunts in movies. Bruce wants his movies to make people think. People learn values from Bruce's movies.

Bruce is more than an actor. Bruce directs movies. Bruce produces movies. Bruce writes movie scripts.

The Star Still Shines

Bruce makes martial arts popular. Martial arts schools open around the world. Many other actors star in martial arts movies. Every movie wants a star like Bruce Lee. But there is only one Bruce Lee.

Bruce Lee dies in 1973. He is only 32 years old. He leaves behind his wife, Linda. He leaves behind two small children. Bruce leaves behind books and movies, which people still enjoy. The world misses Bruce Lee and his teachings.

Fact: Bruce dies from a reaction to pain medicine.